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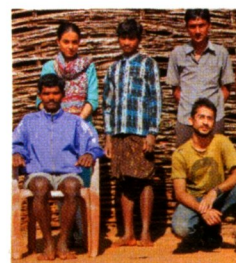
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The threats to India's internal security have been a matter of growing concern, from Punjab militancy to insurgency in the North-east, Islamic Jihadi groups, Dawood Ibrahim and his D Company. But the one which is the longest running, least publicised and probably the most dangerous is by the Naxalites or Maoists. It is only in recent times, however, that the Naxalite menace is being treated by the Centre with the seriousness it deserves. The prime minister, at a recent conference, stated, "It would not be an exaggeration to say that the problem of Naxalism is the single biggest internal security challenge ever faced by our country."

It has been 40 years since Charu Mazumdar laid the seeds of a peasant revolution in Naxalbari village in Darjeeling district. Since then the Naxalite movement has lost much of its intellectual attraction, but gained in strength and spread to over 160 districts cutting a swathe across the country. It has attracted disparate but highly committed elements who swear by violence. The movement is now characterised by an army-style organisation, sophisticated weapons and explosives, well trained cadres and an excellent intelligence network. They are, in fact, an invisible army in our midst. Their attacks are well coordinated and they choose high-profile targets such as the then Andhra Pradesh chief minister who barely escaped with his life when his car was blown up in 2003. Over 2,000 people have been killed in Maoist violence between January 2003 and June 2007.

To get an inside view of how they operate, their training methods, ideology, arms, motivation and leadership, INDIA TODAY's Principal Correspondent Satarupa Bhattacharjya bravely used her communist contacts to get a message through to the main Maoist group in Chhattisgarh to allow her and Senior Photographer Ishan Tankha to spend time with them deep in the jungles where they have their camps. They travelled to the Maoist hotbed of Dantewada and spent four days and nights in the forests of Abujmah where entire villages are controlled by the Maoists. "Our main concern was that we may get involved in an armed encounter between the Maoists and the security forces but in the jungles they are supreme. Also their morale is very high", says Bhattacharjya.

Our cover story goes beyond the exclusive inside look at the Maoist camps and analyses the extent of the threat emanating from the so-called Red Corridor, embracing the jungles of Chhattisgarh, Andhra Pradesh, Orissa, Maharashtra and the tribal areas of Madhya Pradesh, Jharkhand, Bihar and West Bengal. The irony is that as the Indian economy booms many prosper but the ranks of the dispossessed are rising too. They are easy prey for the Naxalites' call for social and economic justice. This story should serve as a reminder to the benefactors of economic growth that all is not well in their Camelot and many dangers lurk ahead.



Bhattacharjya and Tankha with the Maoists

Aaron Purie
(Aron Purie)